Supplementary Materials

What Is Critical Race Theory? Information Seeking, Place, and the Politics of Racial Threat in the 2022 Midterms

October 28, 2026

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Appendix A: Codebook for Related Topics and Queries

For each term or phrase, code one of the following categories. When categorizing, use the most manifest interpretation of the term or phrase, but also consider that the term or phrase was searched in the context of the search term "critical race theory." Categories were created considering Smith et al. (2025).

1 = General inquiry

- Terms or phrases generally inquiring into critical race theory. This includes general searches for critical race theory, general definitions, explanations, and other inquiries not linked to a specific policy, race, or political debates.
- Includes any deviation of the phrase "critical race theory" or "critical thinking."
- *Examples:* theory, definition, Wikipedia

2 = Politics, law, and elections

- Terms or phrases mentioning political actors (e.g., Ron DeSantis, Ted Cruz), political organizations (The Heritage Foundation, TurningPointUSA), political ideology (e.g., conservatism), political party, political influencers (e.g., Chris Rufo), political commentators (e.g., John Oliver, John Stewart), amendments, laws, bills, legislation, elections (e.g., midterm), courts, and judges (e.g., Justice Ketanji Jackson).
  - Includes mentions of political party, elections, political conflict, elected officials, government actions, court cases, policies (e.g., affirmative action), and legal decisions related to critical race theory. Also includes searches for certain cities/states (as they are searched with critical race theory).
  - *Note:* Feel free to search the name if unsure of the political actor.
- *Examples:* Republican Party, Governor, legislation, bill, court ruling, ban

3 = Education and education policy

- Terms and phrases mentioning education, schools, curriculum (and policies concerning curriculum and textbooks), teaching, books, textbooks, library, education standards, school districts, school boards, unions, teachers, and parents (including parents' rights).
- *Examples:* curriculum, teacher, school board, K-12, child, district, books (including book ban)

4 = Sexual orientation and gender

- Terms or phrases mentioning transgender, LGBTQ, gender, gender ideology.
- *Examples:* trans, transgender, gender identity

5 = Race and racism

- Terms and phrases mentioning race, racism, and the history of race in the United States. This includes mentions of anti-racism, racial inequality/racism, institutional racism, bias, identity, civil rights, and racial groups (e.g., white people, Black people).
- *Examples:* race, racism, bias, white privilege, Black history, Jim Crow, The Great Replacement

6 = Critical race theory scholarship

- Terms and phrases mentioning critical race or race-related scholarship. This is more in-depth than general inquiry, as the topic centers on the scholarship and literature that informs critical race theory. This includes mentions of prominent CRT scholars, related academic concepts, books, and broader references to race scholarship.
  - *Note:* Consider, is this an academic term, perspective, or field? Feel free to search the name if unsure of the scholar.
- *Examples:* Kimberlé Crenshaw, Richard Delgado, intersectionality, ethnic studies, Google Scholar, social justice, colorblindness

7 = American (democracy) symbolism

- Terms and phrases mentioning America, American ideals, culture, democracy, or threats therein. This includes mentions of the nation, society, democracy (in the abstract), patriotism, traditional values, as well as terms associated with threats to America (e.g., indoctrination, woke, rights, communism, marxism). This category focuses on ideological and cultural searches pertaining to CRT (e.g., cultural traditions).
- *Examples:* patriotism, woke, indoctrination, national security

8 = Religion

- Terms and phrases mentioning religion (e.g., Christianity, faith, church, bible, evangelism), religious organizations (e.g., Southern Baptist Church), or religious figures (e.g., pastor).
- *Examples:* church, Christian, faith, evangelical

9 = Unrelated/unknown

- Terms and phrases unrelated to critical race theory or terms that, on their own, are not clearly connected with the coded categories. This includes terms that are weakly related to or do not have a substantive connection to CRT, race, or related political debates.
- *Examples:* tariffs, FDA lucky charms, climate change

Appendix B: Google Trends Descriptives

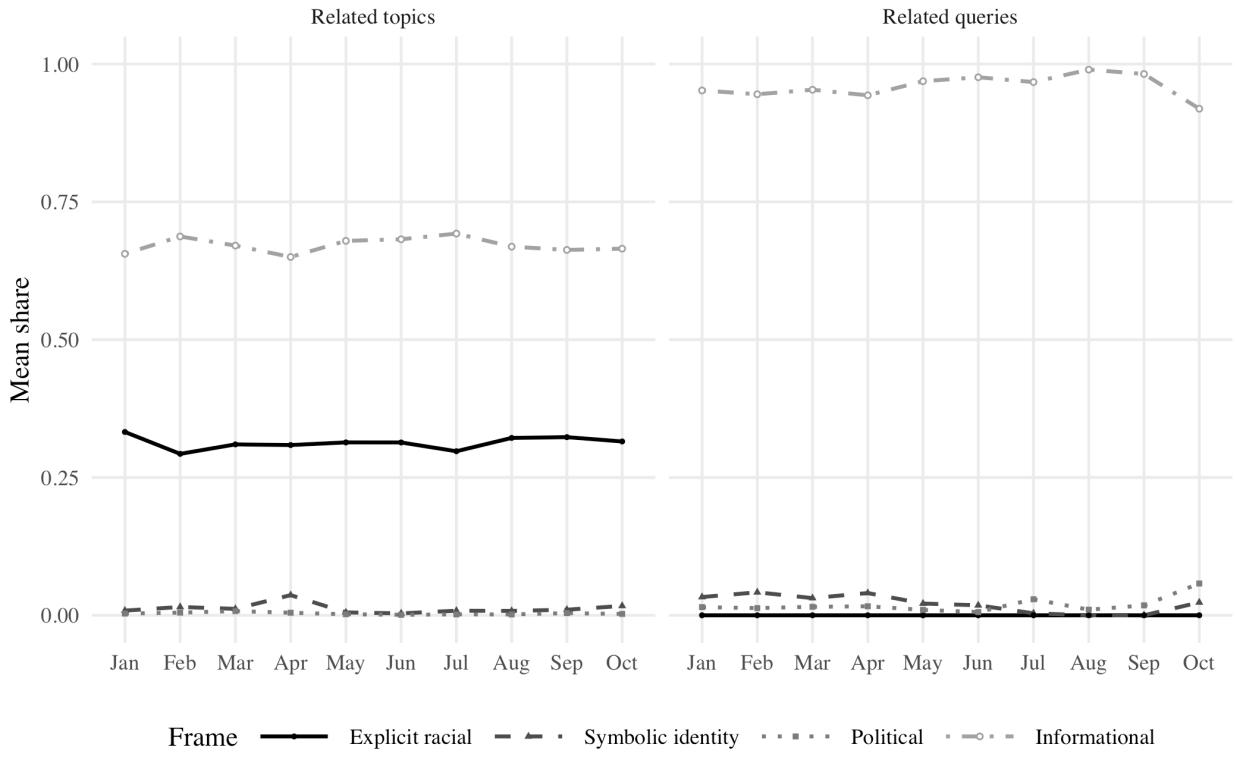


Figure B1: Mean frame shares by month, January to October 2022

Note. Mean share of each frame across state-months with coded terms. A frame's share is the sum of its terms' Google Trends scores divided by the sum of scores for all coded terms in that state-month. Frames: explicit racial (code 5), Symbolic identity (3, 4, 7, 8), political (2), informational (1, 6).

Table B1: Coverage of related topics and queries

Measure	Related topics	Related queries
State-months with coded terms (of 500)	453	388
States	50	50
Terms (all)	2623	712
Terms excluded as unrelated or uncoded (%)	1.3	0.4
Unique coded terms	126	53
Coded terms per state-month, M (SD)	5.72 (3.79)	1.83 (1.90)

Note. Google Trends related topics and queries for "critical race theory," requested separately for each state and month, January to October 2022. A state-month is one state in one month. State-months below Google's reporting threshold return no related terms.

Table B2: Prevalence of content categories

Code	Category	Frame	Unique terms	States	Months	M share	M share when trended
Related topics							
1	General inquiry	Informational	12	50	10	.67	.67
2	Politics, law, and elections	Political	48	25	10	.00	.02
3	Education and education policy	Symbolic identity	25	40	10	.01	.03
4	Sexual orientation and gender	Symbolic identity	3	8	7	.00	.01
5	Race and racism	Explicit racial	13	50	10	.31	.31
6	CRT scholarship	Informational	12	23	8	.00	.02
7	America and American democracy symbolism	Symbolic identity	10	14	10	.00	.01
8	Religion	Symbolic identity	3	4	3	.00	.00
Related queries							
1	General inquiry	Informational	16	50	10	.94	.94
2	Politics, law, and elections	Political	20	12	10	.02	.21
3	Education and education policy	Symbolic identity	13	23	8	.02	.14
4	Sexual orientation and gender	Symbolic identity	0	0	0	.00	
5	Race and racism	Explicit racial	0	0	0	.00	
6	CRT scholarship	Informational	4	23	8	.02	.16
7	America and American democracy symbolism	Symbolic identity	0	0	0	.00	
8	Religion	Symbolic identity	0	0	0	.00	

Note. States and months = number of states (of 50) and months (of 10) in which the category trended at least once. Share = the category's summed Google Trends scores divided by the summed scores of all coded terms in a state-month. M share = mean share across all state-months with coded terms, counting 0 where the category did not trend. M share when trended = mean share only in state-months where the category trended; blank when it never trended.

Table B3: Most frequent related topics by category

Term	n	M score	SD score	States
1. General inquiry				
critical race theory	453	97.23	6.92	50
theory	450	97.68	5.34	50
critical thinking	200	22.64	13.19	49
what is critical race theory	94	7.26	4.54	39
wikipedia	26	5.35	3.67	17
2. Politics, law, and elections				
ban	38	2.11	1.01	14
bill	31	2.23	2.39	13
republican party	15	1.50	0.65	7
ketanji brown jackson	14	1.86	0.86	14
law	13	3.38	1.61	10
3. Education and education policy				
education	148	4.68	2.75	35
teacher	92	3.51	2.33	28
mathematics	34	6.91	2.71	33

Table B3: Most frequent related topics by category *(continued)*

Term	n	M score	SD score	States
textbook	20	2.85	1.23	20
critical race theory in mathematics education	16	2.73	1.49	16
4. Sexual orientation and gender				
gender	9	1.22	0.44	7
feminism	3	1.00	0.00	2
planned parenthood	2	8.50	4.95	1
5. Race and racism				
race	452	95.69	8.14	50
racism	73	2.79	1.97	23
white people	12	2.08	1.31	7
african americans	11	1.55	0.69	9
black people	8	1.62	1.06	7
6. CRT scholarship				
critical race theory: an introduction	45	5.44	3.96	23
intersectionality	8	1.57	0.79	4
sociology	4	1.67	0.58	4
richard delgado	3	3.00		3
thesis	1	5.00		1
7. America and American democracy symbolism				
woke	22	2.00	0.95	9
society	12	2.92	3.12	7
marxism	6	1.33	0.82	4
culture	5	1.60	0.89	3
americans	3	2.33	1.15	3
8. Religion				
crucifixion	3	1.33	0.58	3
pastor	1	1.00		1
religion	1	1.00		1

Note. Up to five terms per category, ranked by the number of times the term appears in the data (n), then by mean score. n = number of state-months in which the term trended. M score and SD score = mean and standard deviation of the term's Google Trends score (0 to 100, relative to the top related term in the state-month); SD is blank for terms observed once. States = number of states in which the term trended at least once. Categories with no terms are omitted.

Table B4: Most frequent related queries by category

Term	n	M score	SD score	States
1. General inquiry				
what is critical race theory	386	99.95	0.72	50
what is the critical race theory	30	17.97	6.95	15
critical race theory wikipedia	25	21.20	21.10	11
critical race theory definition	23	21.78	15.36	10
define critical race theory	16	6.12	3.52	9
2. Politics, law, and elections				

Table B4: Most frequent related queries by category *(continued)*

Term	n	M score	SD score	States
critical race theory texas	8	44.75	27.34	1
critical race theory florida	5	31.60	3.21	1
critical race theory georgia	4	30.25	20.52	1
critical race theory alabama	4	29.75	8.62	1
paris climate agreement	3	8.33	6.81	3
3. Education and education policy				
critical race theory in education	35	13.66	7.17	16
critical race theory in schools	24	16.62	5.62	14
what is critical race theory in education	12	3.83	2.08	6
critical race theory math textbooks	11	9.36	3.96	11
critical race theory book	5	36.80	36.49	5
6. CRT scholarship				
critical race theory an introduction	41	26.49	18.28	22
google scholar	1	8.00		1
intersectionality	1	8.00		1
kimberle crenshaw	1	5.00		1

Note. Up to five terms per category, ranked by the number of times the term appears in the data (n), then by mean score. n = number of state-months in which the term trended. M score and SD score = mean and standard deviation of the term's Google Trends score (0 to 100, relative to the top related term in the state-month); SD is blank for terms observed once. States = number of states in which the term trended at least once. Categories with no terms are omitted.

Table B5: Co-occurrence of frames

Frame pair	Both trended (%)	r
Related topics		
Explicit racial and symbolic identity	42.6	-.19***
Explicit racial and political	21.2	-.11*
Explicit racial and informational	99.8	-.82***
Symbolic identity and political	18.1	.29***
Symbolic identity and informational	42.6	-.38***
Political and informational	21.2	-.24***
Related queries		
Explicit racial and symbolic identity	0.0	
Explicit racial and political	0.0	
Explicit racial and informational	0.0	
Symbolic identity and political	4.1	.04
Symbolic identity and informational	16.2	-.62***
Political and informational	8.5	-.81***

Note. Both trended (%) = percentage of state-months with coded terms in which both frames trended. r = Pearson correlation between the two frames' shares across state-months; blank when a frame never trended in the source. Shares sum to 1, so correlations are pushed negative by construction. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

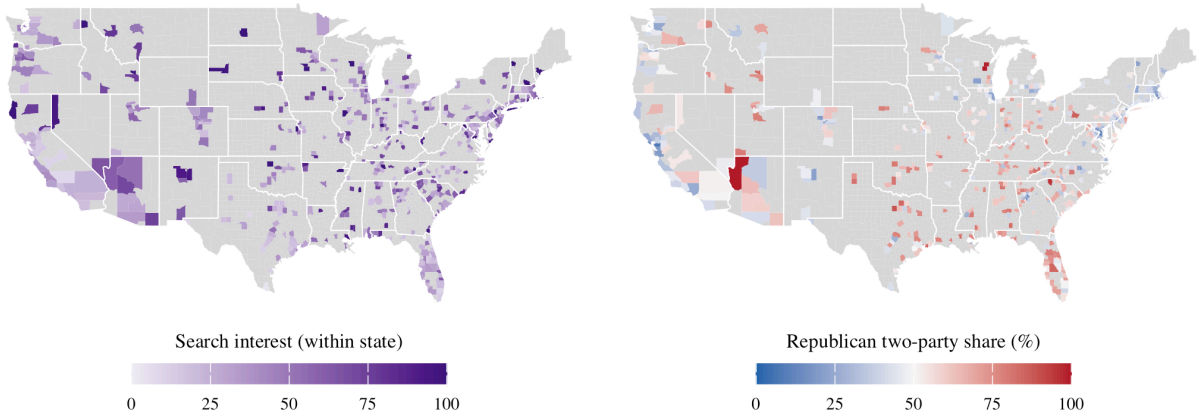


Figure B2: County search interest in critical race theory (left) and Republican share of the two-party 2022 U.S. House vote (right)

Note. Left: mean Google Trends search interest for "critical race theory" by county, January to October 2022. Scores are scaled within each state (top city = 100), so shading compares counties within a state, not across states. Right: Republican share of the two-party 2022 U.S. House vote, Republican votes / (Republican + Democratic votes) × 100, for the same counties. Grey = county without measurable search interest or (right) without a two-party contest. Alaska and Hawaii are not drawn.

Appendix C: ANES Measures and MRP Estimates

Table C1: ANES 2020 variables used in the MRP models

Measure	Variable	Question wording	Response options (as coded in analysis)
Status threat	V202488	In general, does the federal government treat whites better than blacks, treat them both the same, or treat blacks better than whites?	1 = Treat whites better; 2 = Treat both the same; 3 = Treat blacks better
Media salience	V202407	How closely do you follow politics on TV, radio, newspapers, or the Internet?	1 = Not at all; 2 = Not very closely; 3 = Fairly closely; 4 = Very closely
Racial resentment	V202300	'Irish, Italian, Jewish and many other minorities overcame prejudice and worked their way up. Blacks should do the same without any special favors.'	1 = Agree strongly; 2 = Agree somewhat; 3 = Neither agree nor disagree; 4 = Disagree somewhat; 5 = Disagree strongly
Racial resentment	V202301	'Generations of slavery and discrimination have created conditions that make it difficult for blacks to work their way out of the lower class.' (reverse)	1 = Agree strongly; 2 = Agree somewhat; 3 = Neither agree nor disagree; 4 = Disagree somewhat; 5 = Disagree strongly
Racial resentment	V202302	'Over the past few years, blacks have gotten less than they deserve.' (reverse)	1 = Agree strongly; 2 = Agree somewhat; 3 = Neither agree nor disagree; 4 = Disagree somewhat; 5 = Disagree strongly
Racial resentment	V202303	'It's really a matter of some people not trying hard enough; if blacks would only try harder they could be just as well off as whites.'	1 = Agree strongly; 2 = Agree somewhat; 3 = Neither agree nor disagree; 4 = Disagree somewhat; 5 = Disagree strongly

Table C2: Multilevel Models of Racial Resentment, Status Threat, and Media Salience

Predictor	Racial resentment	Status threat	Media salience
Intercept	2.72 [2.30, 3.13]		
Threshold 1		-0.03 [-0.52, 0.45]	-2.08 [-2.54, -1.61]
Threshold 2		2.25 [1.75, 2.74]	0.04 [-0.42, 0.51]
Threshold 3			2.26 [1.79, 2.73]
Female	-0.15 [-0.21, -0.09]	-0.30 [-0.42, -0.20]	-0.40 [-0.50, -0.29]
Age 25–34	0.32 [0.12, 0.51]	0.22 [-0.16, 0.60]	0.06 [-0.25, 0.37]
Age 35–44	0.50 [0.31, 0.69]	0.52 [0.14, 0.89]	0.16 [-0.15, 0.46]
Age 45–54	0.75 [0.55, 0.94]	0.91 [0.53, 1.29]	0.43 [0.13, 0.73]
Age 55–64	0.66 [0.47, 0.84]	0.84 [0.46, 1.21]	0.96 [0.66, 1.25]
Age 65+	0.71 [0.52, 0.89]	0.98 [0.61, 1.35]	1.24 [0.95, 1.54]
County Trump vote share, 2020	0.25 [0.20, 0.31]	0.30 [0.20, 0.40]	-0.17 [-0.25, -0.08]
County change in % non-Hispanic White	-0.03 [-0.08, 0.01]	0.01 [-0.08, 0.09]	0.01 [-0.06, 0.07]
County median income	-0.06 [-0.09, -0.03]	-0.03 [-0.10, 0.03]	-0.03 [-0.08, 0.03]
County median age	-0.06 [-0.11, -0.01]	-0.04 [-0.13, 0.05]	0.05 [-0.03, 0.13]
County population (log)	0.01 [-0.05, 0.07]	0.04 [-0.06, 0.14]	0.04 [-0.05, 0.12]
State Trump vote share, 2020	-0.01 [-0.09, 0.06]	0.03 [-0.09, 0.15]	-0.06 [-0.15, 0.03]

Table C2: Multilevel Models of Racial Resentment, Status Threat, and Media Salience *(continued)*

Predictor	Racial resentment	Status threat	Media salience
Region: Northeast	-0.02 [-0.22, 0.17]	0.03 [-0.25, 0.31]	0.09 [-0.10, 0.30]
Region: South	0.15 [0.00, 0.28]	0.38 [0.17, 0.59]	0.23 [0.08, 0.39]
Region: West	-0.15 [-0.31, 0.02]	-0.10 [-0.35, 0.16]	0.06 [-0.12, 0.24]

Note. Posterior means with 95% credible intervals. Racial resentment: Gaussian model. Status threat (V202488) and Media salience (V202407): cumulative logit models (log-odds); thresholds replace the intercept. County and state predictors are standardized across counties and states. Reference categories: male, age 18-24, and the Midwest region. All models include random intercepts for county, state, education, and education by age. 2020 American National Election Studies.

Table C3: Random Effects, Sample, and Convergence Diagnostics

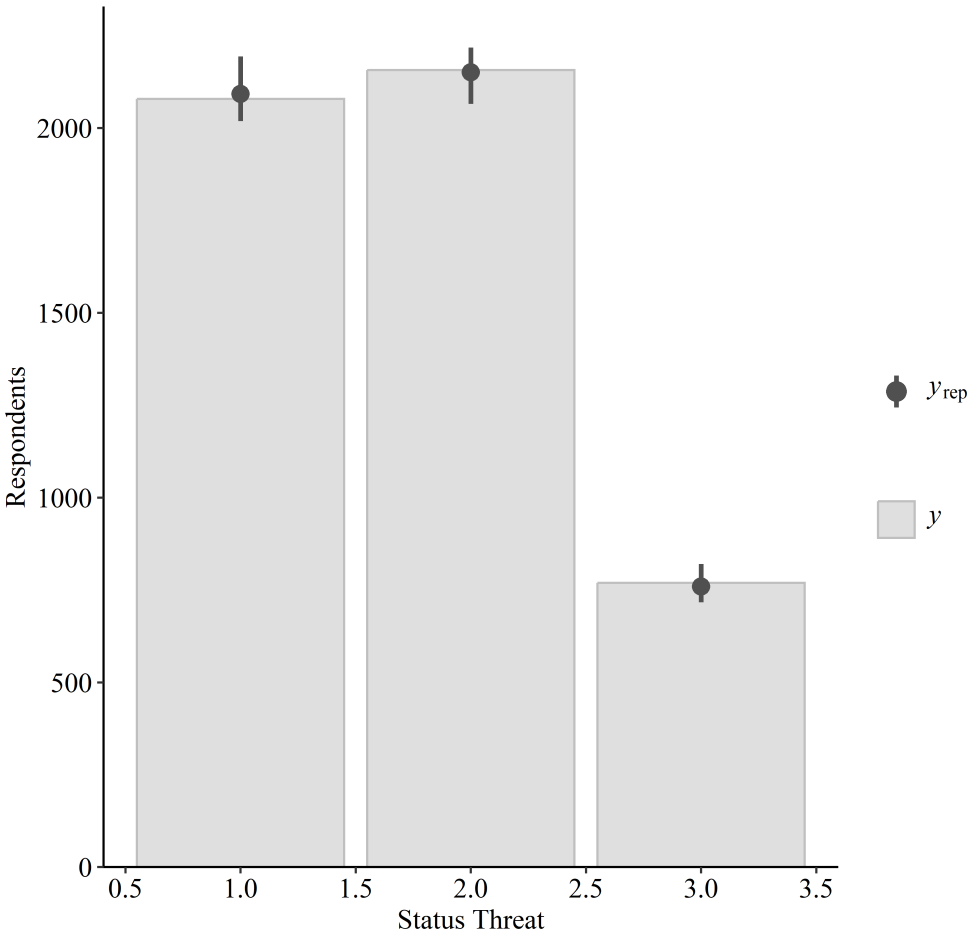
Panel	Parameter	Racial resentment	Status threat	Media salience
Random effects	County SD	0.10 [0.01, 0.18]	0.34 [0.19, 0.46]	0.07 [0.00, 0.19]
	Education SD	0.41 [0.22, 0.80]	0.38 [0.18, 0.75]	0.42 [0.20, 0.82]
	Education × age SD	0.05 [0.00, 0.11]	0.17 [0.07, 0.28]	0.06 [0.00, 0.16]
	State SD	0.13 [0.07, 0.21]	0.15 [0.01, 0.29]	0.07 [0.00, 0.17]
	Residual SD	1.09 [1.07, 1.12]		
Sample and diagnostics	Respondents	5,095	5,005	5,089
	Counties	1,380	1,366	1,380
	States	50	50	50
	Divergent transitions	0	0	0
	Maximum R-hat	1.01	1.01	1.01
	Minimum bulk ESS	622	886	1,364
	Minimum tail ESS	1,592	853	2,640

Note. Random-effect SDs are posterior means with 95% credible intervals. Residual SD applies to the Gaussian model only. R-hat near 1 and large effective sample sizes (ESS) indicate convergence. 4 chains; 3000 iterations.

Table C4: County Estimates of Racial Resentment, Status Threat, and Media salience

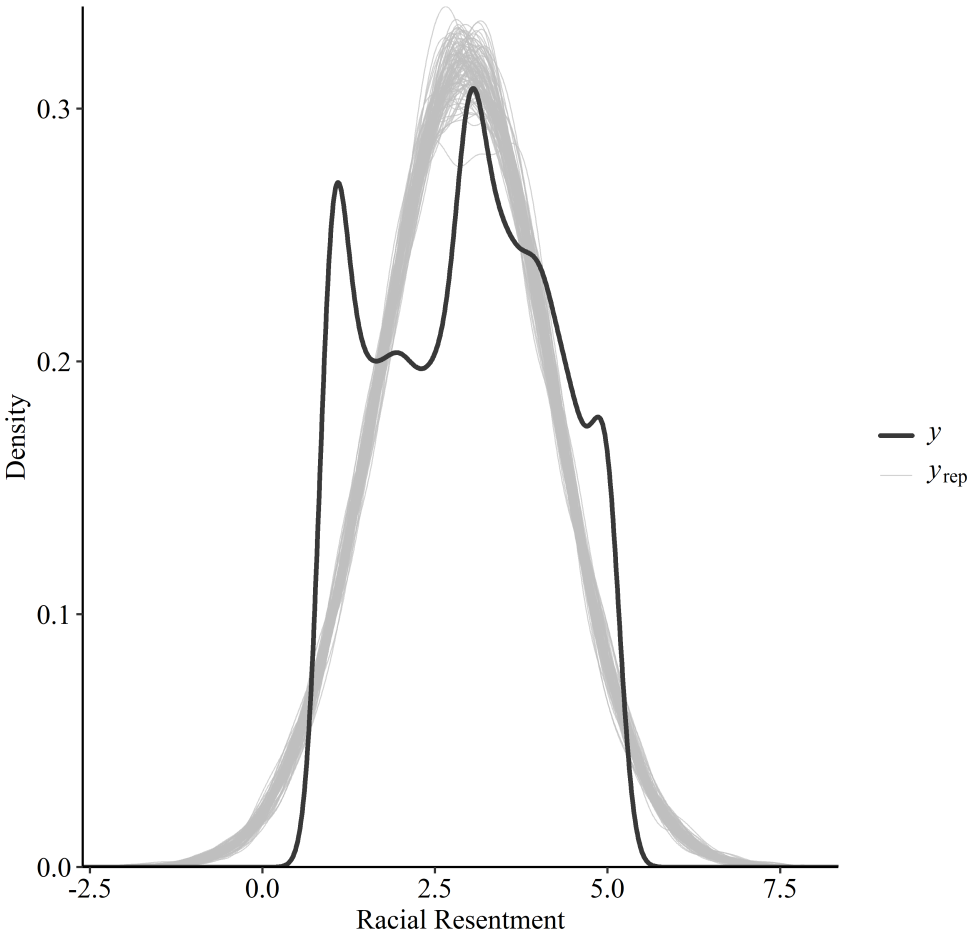
Variable	M	SD	Mean posterior SD	1	2
1. Racial resentment	3.31	0.34	0.15	—	
2. Status threat	1.87	0.15	0.13	.94***	—
3. Media salience	2.67	0.11	0.06	-.67***	-.54***

Note. n = 3,138 counties. Estimates are posterior means from multilevel regression and poststratification; minimum and maximum are not reported. Mean posterior SD = average uncertainty of a county estimate. Correlations are Pearson r across counties. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.



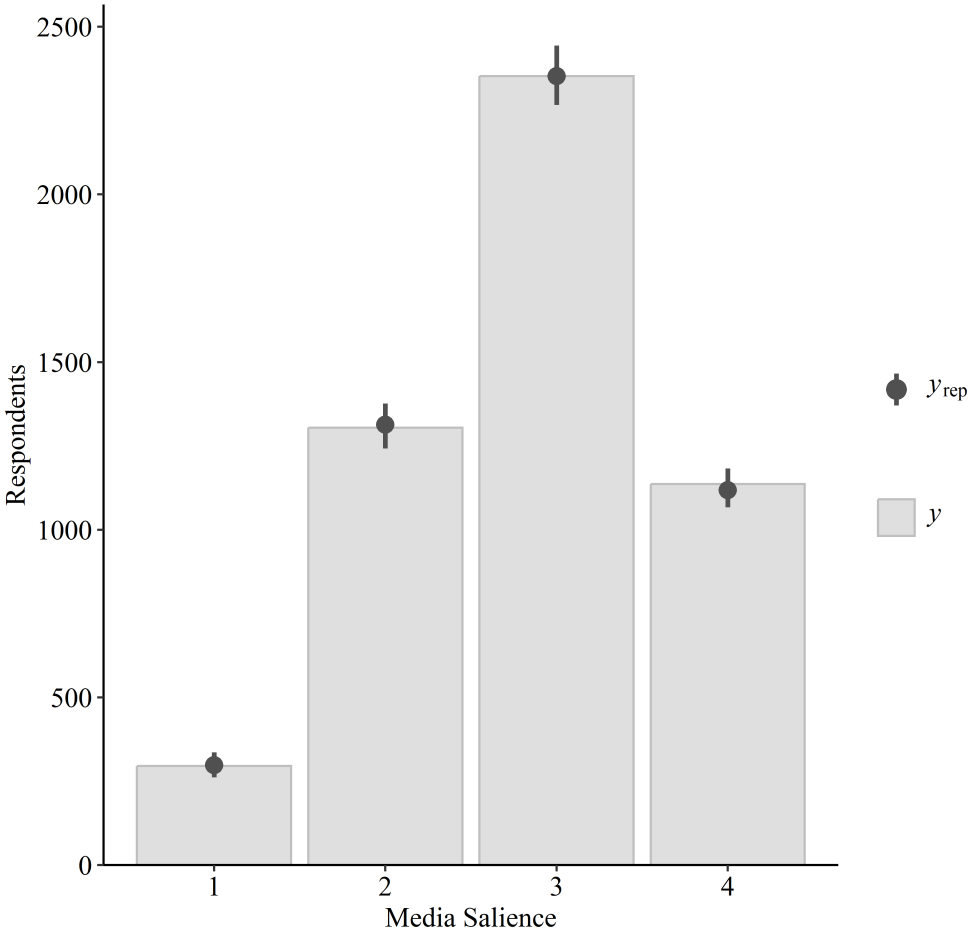
Note. Posterior Predictive Check. y = observed number of respondents in each response category. y_rep = median and 90% posterior predictive interval across 100 datasets simulated from the model.

Figure C1: Posterior predictive check: status threat



Note. Posterior Predictive Check. y = distribution of observed scores.
y_rep = distributions of scores in 100 datasets simulated from the model.

Figure C2: Posterior predictive check: racial resentment



Note. Posterior Predictive Check. y = observed number of respondents in each response category. y_rep = median and 90% posterior predictive interval across 100 datasets simulated from the model.

Figure C3: Posterior predictive check: media salience

Appendix D: Search Interest Models

Table D1: Status Threat and Racial Resentment Predicting County Search Interest

Predictor	Model 1: Status threat	Model 2: Racial resentment
Fixed effects		
Status threat	0.16 (0.06)**	—
Racial resentment	—	0.10 (0.08)
Media salience	-0.01 (0.06)	-0.05 (0.08)
Population (log)	-0.40 (0.04)***	-0.40 (0.04)***
Intercept	0.00 (0.04)	0.00 (0.04)
Random effects		
State SD	0.00	0.00
Residual SD	0.87	0.87
Model fit		
AIC	1,354.33	1,359.54
ΔAIC	0.00	5.21
Counties	526	526
States	50	50

Note. Outcome: county Google Trends search interest (0–100, scaled within state). County attitudes are MRP estimates from the ANES. Predictors are centered within state and standardized; coefficients represent the change in search interest per 1 SD increase in the predictor, within state. Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Table D2: Analytic Samples

Sample	Counties	States	Single-county states
Search models	526	50	6
Mediation models and path models	501	48	5

Note. Counties with measurable Google Trends search interest and MRP estimates. Mediation models exclude counties without a two-party House contest. Single-county states contribute no within-state variation.

Table D3: Descriptive Statistics for Counties

Variable	n	M	SD	Min	Max
Republican two-party share, 2022 (%)	501	52.69	17.34	8.19	100.00
Search interest	501	43.61	24.53	3.00	100.00
Status threat (MRP)	501	1.75	0.16		
Racial resentment (MRP)	501	2.99	0.37		
Media salience (MRP)	501	2.77	0.11		
Population, 2020	501	454,270	715,509	7,348	10,014,009
Trump vote share, 2020 (%)	501	49.52	15.32	8.91	83.57
Change in % non-Hispanic White, 2010-2020	501	-6.24	2.76	-22.96	2.94
Median age	501	38.25	4.85	23.50	68.00
Median household income ($)	501	68,532	17,943	36,496	147,111

Note. Counties in the mediation models. Search interest is the mean Google Trends score for "critical race theory," January to October 2022 (0-100, scaled within state). MRP = county estimates from multilevel regression and poststratification of the 2020 ANES; minimum and maximum are not reported.

Table D4: Correlations Among Model Variables

Variable	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5
1. Search interest	0.00	19.80	—				
2. Status threat	0.00	0.10	.35***	—			
3. Racial resentment	0.00	0.26	.35***	.91***	—		
4. Media salience	0.00	0.07	-.36***	-.78***	-.87***	—	
5. Population (log)	0.00	0.87	-.49***	-.43***	-.48***	.51***	—
6. Republican two-party share, 2022	52.69	17.34	.30***	.67***	.68***	-.65***	-.35***

Note. n = 501 counties. Pearson r. All variables except House margin are centered within state (county value minus state mean), so correlations are within-state. Status threat and racial resentment are too highly correlated to include in the same model; status_threat and racial resentment are modeled separately. * p < .05. ** p < .01. *** p < .001.

Table D5: Correlation Between County Search Interest and Population

Measure	Value
Pooled within-state correlation (Spearman)	-.47
Median state correlation (Spearman)	-.42
States with a negative correlation	34
States tested	41

Note. Spearman correlations between search interest and county population. Pooled: within-state centered values across all counties. By state: states with 3 or more counties.